

Verbal Reasoning

Verbal reasoning is the ability to understand and reason using concepts that are framed in words. It aims to assess a child's ability to think constructively with a series of verbal reasoning questions.

Children perform better in verbal reasoning tests if they read widely and have an extensive vocabulary. Playing lots of word games at home can also help your child with verbal reasoning tests. Try activities such as letter tile games, crosswords and word searches.

The types of questions a child might be asked could focus on:

- finding synonyms and antonyms;
- finding a letter that will complete two words, e.g. woo (d) oor;
- finding a word hidden inside another word, e.g. the word pen hidden inside independent;
- spotting the odd one out in a list of words;
- breaking a code where each letter of the alphabet is represented by a different letter or number.

Here is an example of the type of question you may get in this section:

1. Circle the pair of words which are closest in meaning:

mean, scary

horrible, repulsive

repugnant, repulsive

scary, repulsive

The answer to this question would be 'repugnant, repulsive' as they can both arouse strong feelings of disgust.

For a thorough guide to all aspects of the 11+ test, try our [Survival Guide for Parents/Carers](#).



Closest in Meaning



Words that have similar meanings are called **synonyms**.

Some examples of synonyms include:



In the questions on this test, you will need to find the two words that are **closest** in meaning.

However, be careful – not all words that are **close** in meaning are the **closest** in meaning.

For example, take these three synonyms:

short minuscule tiny

All these words are synonyms for **small**. They all mean 'lacking in size'. However, **minuscule** and **tiny** are closer in meaning, because they mean small in all ways, whilst **short** only refers to being small in height or length.

You might also need to think about the intensity of the words.

For example:

warm and boiling
roasting and boiling
humid and roasting
balmy and boiling

The pair **roasting** and **boiling** are the closest in meaning. All the words have a similar meaning – they all refer to something having a high temperature. However, **roasting** and **boiling** both hint towards a higher intensity of that meaning than any of the other pairs.



11+ Verbal Reasoning Practice Paper

Closest in Meaning: Test 1

Circle the pair of words which are closest in meaning.

a.

whisper, chat

explain, exclaim

shout, exclaim

whisper, explain

b.

smell, fragrance

essence, fragrance

stench, stink

stench, fragrance

c.

walk, sprint

jog, amble

amble, sprint

dawdle, amble

d.

sweep, brush

clean, wash

tidy, sweep

brush, clean

e.

bored, tired

exhausted, distressed

sleepy, tired

tired, bored

f.

apartment, house

house, bungalow

flat, apartment

dwelling, bungalow

g.

splash, spill

bubble, splash

spill, drop

drop, slosh

h.

dance, skip

skip, bounce

hop, dance

hop, skip



11+ Verbal Reasoning Practice Paper: Answers

Closest in Meaning: Test 1

a. **shout, exclaim**

All the words are verbs used as synonyms for talking. **Shout** and **exclaim** are both used for talking loudly and excitedly.

b. **stench, stink**

All the words are nouns for a type of smell. **Stench** and **stink** are both used to mean a strong, bad smell.

c. **dawdle, amble**

All the words are verbs used as synonyms for walking. **Dawdle** and **amble** are both used to mean walking slowly or aimlessly.

d. **sweep, brush**

All the words are verbs on the topic of cleaning. **Sweep** and **brush** are both types of cleaning which use the same motion and use of a broom or brush.

e. **sleepy, tired**

All the words are adjectives to describe a state of being. **Sleepy** and **tired** both refer to a lack of sleep.

f. **flat, apartment**

All the words are nouns for a type of place to live. **Flat** and **apartment** are both types of single-story homes which are not exclusively on the ground floor.

g. **spill, drop**

All the words are verbs on the topic of water. **Spill** and **drop** are also related to accidentally making a mess with liquids.

h. **hop, skip**

All the words are verbs used for movement. **Hop** and **skip** are both types of jump.

11+ Verbal Reasoning Practice Paper

Closest in Meaning: Test 2

Find and underline two words, one from each group, that are the closest in meaning.

- a. (cloudy, dim, bright) (dull, chilly, frosty)

- b. (carbonated, flat, bubbles) (spicy, fizzy, strong)

- c. (dive, slide, climb) (clamber, race, creep)

- d. (gossip, listen, babble) (chant, ramble, rant)

- e. (robust, blooming, delicate) (sturdy, lethargic, wobbly)

- f. (shame, untrue, doubtful) (humble, certain, dubious)

- g. (lament, bellow, grunt) (warble, weep, giggle)



11+ Verbal Reasoning Practice Paper: Answers

Closest in Meaning: Test 2

- a. (cloudy, **dim**, bright) (**dull**, chilly, frosty)

Dim and **dull** both mean a lack of colour or brightness.

- b. (**carbonated**, flat, bubbles) (spicy, **fizzy**, strong)

Carbonated and **fizzy** both describe carbonated soft drinks.

- c. (dive, slide, **climb**) (**clamber**, race, creep)

Climb and **clamber** both mean to move upwards, e.g. up a wall.

- d. (gossip, listen, **babble**) (chant, **ramble**, rant)

Babble and **ramble** both mean to chatter non-stop

- e. (**robust**, blooming, delicate) (**sturdy**, lethargic, wobbly)

Robust and **sturdy** are both used to describe something strong and hardy.

- f. (shame, untrue, **doubtful**) (humble, certain, **dubious**)

Doubtful and **dubious** both describe something uncertain.

- g. (**lament**, bellow, grunt) (warble, **weep**, giggle)

Lament and **weep** both mean to make sad, crying sounds.